

Mini Marvel

One of the sleekest PDA phones in the market, the new Xda II Mini from O2 runs Microsoft Windows Mobile 2003 PocketPC Phone Second Edition and is a tri-band GSM/GPRS device. It is sleek and is encased in a silver body with ribbed black sides and curved corners.

The layout makes it easy to handle, with the camera button, volume slider and voice recorder keys on the left, the MMC/SDIO slot on top, the power button next to the stylus silo, the IR port on the right and the headphone jack next to the USB port at the bottom.

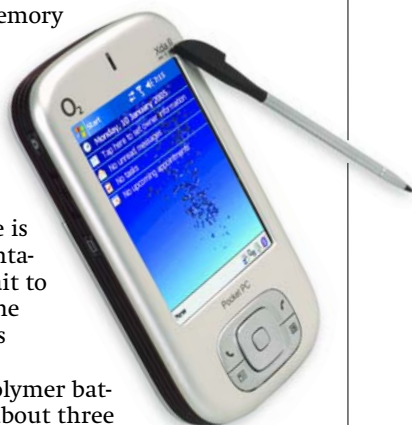
The front fascia is neatly laid out as well, with minimal controls. A square-shaped bank of keys under the screen is comprised of an enter/action key in the centre surrounded by a four-way navigation key. This is flanked by symmetrically designed 'Send' and 'End' keys on top and two application buttons assigned to 'Contacts' and 'Calendar' at the bottom. The camera, voice recorder, contacts and calendar buttons can be re-assigned to other applications, depending on your preferences. The lens and a self-portrait mirror are at the back.

With an Intel PXA 272 processor providing 416 MHz of horsepower, and 64MB of flash ROM and 64MB of RAM under the hood, the Mini boasts a 2.8-inch TFT LCD touch screen that can display 64K colours at a resolution of 240 x 320. Connectivity options include Bluetooth and infrared,

with support for additional memory through the MMC/SDIO slot. A 256 MB SD card is bundled.

Voice clarity on the O2 Xda II Mini is excellent, even with the speakerphone. The screen is clear and vibrant, but you may face issues in direct sunlight. A neat feature is the ability to change the orientation of the screen from portrait to landscape with just a tap of the stylus—handy for spreadsheets and documents.

The 1,200 mAh Lithium Polymer battery should see you through about three days with standard phone and PDA use. Overall, good features and the sleek form factor are the highlights of the package. Poor image quality from the camera and the high price tag are the potential deterrents.



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Rating

Orite MV-3115

Love's Labour Lost

This is probably love at first sight. You will fall for this beauty, which incorporates a still camera, a video camera, a voice recorder, a Web camera, a movie viewer and MP3 support, the moment you lay your eyes on the packaging—with the glitzy model holding up the device in all its shining glory! Your love will grow stronger when you hold it for the first time. But alas, love is blind. No sooner than you've held the device and had a first close-up look, will you want to look away! Starting with the design, which is pretty compact for a device that packs in so much, the Orite will flatter to deceive. It has a small screen that has to be flipped open, and is roughly as big (or small) as that of a Nokia 3310!

The device should come with 16 MB of on-board memory, but the unit we received had only 4MB on-board and no flash cards, tying it down to the PC for good.

To load MP3s onto it, you need to manually go to the device in 'My Computer' and create a directory called 'MP3'. Hereafter, it's drag-and-drop. Photos taken with the "3.2 mp" camera were grainy despite us using the flash, and even worse with the 8x digital zoom! Video at 640 x 480, though, was all right.

The package includes a carry case, a USB charger, cable, driver disk and Ulead PhotoStudio, and is priced at around Rs 9,000. Expensive considering the feature set...



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Krome Intelлект iQ700

It's a phone! It's smart! It's a smartphone! The Intelлект iQ700 is one of the smallest devices running Windows Mobile 2003 Second Edition. Encased in a metallic silver-grey metal-and-plastic body, the device is a tad larger and heavier than a standard candy-bar phone.

Looking inside, it is powered by a TI OMAP 730 200 MHz processor and has 64MB of ROM and 32MB of RAM, topped off with a 2.2-inch 176 x 220 pixel TFT screen.

So what can you do with it? E-mail, MMS, Speed Dial and Voice Tags are supported, and you get all the productivity software built into Windows Mobile 2003. You can play back WAV, WMA, AMR, AAC and MP3. Voice clarity is decent, but the phone does have a problem in areas with low signal strength. The speakerphone is good enough for a small conference room.

As for the operational controls, the five-way rocket switch on the front panel looks quite innovative in terms of design, but also proves to be the phone's nemesis.



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Rating

1 Poor: Has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application. **2 Mediocre:** Does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas. **3 Average:** Reasonably competent, but there is nothing spectacular about the product. **4 Good:** A good buy, better than most products in its category. **5 Excellent:** A brilliant combination of price, performance and features—far beyond expectations.